

GETTY IMAGES

COUNTING EXERCISE
An official collecting census data from a family in Patna, Aug. 2

Smart Pulse Survey in Andhra Pradesh in 2016-17. Both the surveys were linked to Aadhaar numbers and information on caste and other economic indicators were collected. But these findings have not been made public

↘ In **2015**, the Karnataka government, during the previous term of Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, conducted a 'Socio-Economic and Education Survey'. The findings have not been published till now though Siddaramaiah has now decided to accept the results of the survey

↘ In **2018**, then Union Home Minister Rajnath Singh had said that a caste count would be included in the 2021 census. In 2021, the Modi government decided against it, citing logistical reasons. Then Covid put paid to the exercise

↘ In **2023**, the Bihar government conducted and published a caste survey. Odisha government has also initiated a similar one

MANDAL VS KAMANDAL

Several Opposition parties believe that Bihar's caste census data may ignite a fresh round of Mandal politics. In 1990, then PM V.P. Singh pulled out the decade-old Mandal Commission report and announced 27 per cent reservation in government jobs for OBCs. This led to the emergence of caste-based parties, particularly in north India, and the decline of the Congress, which opposed the report, in states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

The BJP, seen as an upper caste party, resorted to the politics of Kamandal—a water pot symbolic of Hinduism—by starting the Ram temple agitation. To counter caste-based politics, it promoted the 'Hindutva' narrative—a subsumption of Hindu identities irrespective of caste—and gained OBC support by deftly weaving caste appeal within Hindutva. With the release of the Bihar caste data, Opposition parties now hope to usher in Mandal 2.0 to counter the BJP. That's why the Congress has abandoned its earlier position and demanded a national caste census and reservation proportionate to the population of the OBCs.

THE BJP COUNTER

A day after Nitish announced the results of the Bihar caste survey, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, speaking at a rally in Jagdalpur in Chhattisgarh, described the Opposition efforts as an attempt to create a divide among Hindus. Jettisoning caste altogether, Modi instead sought to recast the BJP's concern for the people in economic terms. In response to Rahul's '*Jitni aabaadi, utna haq*' slogan, he said, "Their leader said rights should be proportional to population. I say the biggest population is the poor. For me, the poor people have the biggest population, and my mission is their welfare."

Indeed, by creating a massive infrastructure for timely and direct delivery of government welfare schemes and weeding out the need for political and bureaucratic patronage, the Modi government seems to have ensured that caste considerations have ceased to influence voter choices, going by the electoral results. "The effective delivery of services, the evolution of the *labharthi* (beneficiary) constituency has helped BJP dilute caste identity politics," says Badri Narayan, director of the Govind Ballabh Pant Social Science Institute in Allahabad. The BJP's OBC Morcha chief K. Laxman says the party will run massive awareness campaigns across the nation to tell OBC voters what Modi has done for them. "The Nitish Kumar government," he adds, "has released the caste census data with a political motive. They make noise but do little for backward classes. The Modi government has delivered multiple benefits in the past 10 years. That's the reason people from the backward classes are firmly with the BJP."

Psephologist Pradeep Gupta, too, thinks that Modi's record of service delivery will blunt the Opposition's caste-based political narrative. "History says that any party, starting from V.P. Singh's Janata Dal, which has initiated big-ticket reservation for any community has lost the next election," he says. The BJP has also been careful to maintain a significant representation of OBC leaders within the party apparatus and government. The party accounts for 68 per cent of the total OBC MPs in the Lok Sabha while 38 per cent of its total MPs are from OBC communities. The 77-member Modi ministry has 27 OBC ministers.

And while it was initially perceived as a party of Brah-